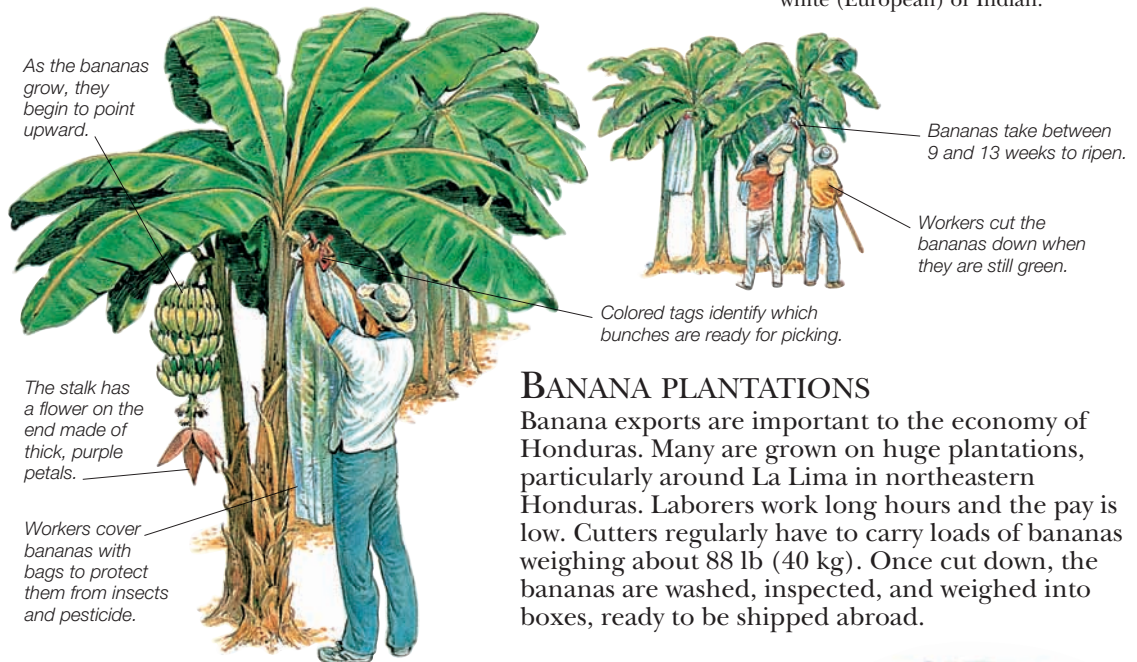


**HONDURAS****Capital city:** Tegucigalpa**Area:** 43,278 sq miles (112,090 sq km)**Population:** 6,900,000**Official language:** Spanish**Major religion:** Christian 100%**Government:** Multiparty democracy**Currency:** Lempira**Adult literacy rate:** 80%**Life expectancy:** 66 years**People per doctor:** 1,250**Televisions:** 90 per 1,000 people**EL SALVADOR****Capital city:** San Salvador**Area:** 8,124 sq miles (21,040 sq km)**Population:** 6,500,000**Official language:** Spanish**Major religion:** Christian 98%, other 2%**Government:** Multiparty democracy**Currency:** Salvadorean colón, US Dollar**Adult literacy rate:** 80%**Life expectancy:** 70 years**People per doctor:** 909**Televisions:** 675 per 1,000 people

HONDURAS

THE HOT, STEAMY CLIMATE of Honduras is ideal for growing fruit, and for many years the banana industry has dominated the life of the country. Today, Honduras has developed other exports, such as coffee, sugar, and beef. About half of the Honduran population lives in the countryside, in small villages or isolated settlements. Many are poor farmers, growing corn, beans, or rice for their own use. Life is hard, and many people go hungry. Land is unevenly distributed – wealthy families and fruit companies own 60 percent of the land.



BANANA PLANTATIONS

Banana exports are important to the economy of Honduras. Many are grown on huge plantations, particularly around La Lima in northeastern Honduras. Laborers work long hours and the pay is low. Cutters regularly have to carry loads of bananas weighing about 88 lb (40 kg). Once cut down, the bananas are washed, inspected, and weighed into boxes, ready to be shipped abroad.

**HONDURAN PEOPLE**

Most Hondurans are *mestizos* – mixed descendants of native Indians and the Europeans who arrived in the 16th century. Some are descended from black Africans who were shipped to the Caribbean as slaves. Some are white (European) or Indian.

EL SALVADOR

THE SMALLEST COUNTRY in Central America, El Salvador has suffered a history of civil war and revolution. Historically, a handful of rich families have controlled the land and wealth, while most Salvadoreans have lived in poverty. A line of volcanoes, many still active, dominates the landscape. Forests, once rich with cedar, mahogany, and oak, have been cut down for farmland.

**SAN SALVADOR**

San Salvador was founded by Spanish colonists in 1525. Since then it has been damaged by earthquakes many times. Much of the original Spanish architecture has been replaced with modern buildings. Overcrowded slum areas have developed around the city as thousands of refugees have arrived in search of work.

**PEACE ACCORD**

Between 1979 and 1991, a bitter civil war raged between the US-backed government and left-wing guerilla forces. Some 75,000 Salvadoreans died. On January 16, 1992, the country celebrated a peace agreement signed by guerilla leader Chano Guevara (left).

**THE SOCCER WAR**

In 1969, long-standing border disputes erupted when El Salvador played Honduras to qualify for the World Cup. The incident led to the Salvadoran army invading Honduras. More than 3,000 people were killed.

Find out more

COFFEE: 50, 62, 66

PEOPLES OF THE CONTINENT: 42

SUGAR: 52

VOLCANOES & EARTHQUAKES: 13